Addis Ababa University Official Student Policies and Regulations

A Comprehensive Guide for Students

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1. Introduction to AAU Policies and Governance

Addis Ababa University (AAU), as Ethiopia's premier higher education institution, operates under a comprehensive legal framework designed to maintain academic excellence, ensure fair treatment of students, and uphold the integrity of the university's degrees and reputation. This guide compiles essential policies that every AAU student must understand and follow throughout their academic journey.

The policies outlined in this document are derived from the AAU Senate Legislation, official university announcements, and published policy documents. Students are expected to familiarize themselves with these regulations, as ignorance of the rules is not considered a valid excuse for violations.

The Legal Framework

AAU's policies are governed by the university's Senate Legislation, which serves as the supreme document for academic and student affairs. References to specific articles of this legislation (e.g., “AAU SL (2024) Articles 95.4 – 95.7”) appear throughout university communications and official decisions. This guide organizes key policy areas into eight sections for easy reference.

2. Academic Integrity Policy

Definition and Importance

Academic integrity is the foundation of the university's educational mission. Addis Ababa University defines academic integrity as the commitment to honest, ethical, and responsible scholarly conduct in all academic work. The university expects all students, faculty, and researchers to adhere to the highest standards of academic honesty.

Core Principles

The university's academic integrity framework rests on several fundamental principles:

- **Honesty:** Students must submit original work and accurately represent their contributions to collaborative projects
- **Trust:** The academic community operates on mutual trust that all members will uphold ethical standards
- **Fairness:** Consistent application of standards ensures all students are evaluated equitably
- **Respect:** Students must respect the intellectual property rights of others through proper attribution

- **Responsibility:** Each student bears personal responsibility for maintaining academic integrity

Institutional Commitment

AAU has demonstrated its commitment to academic integrity through concrete actions. In 2019, the university rescinded a Master's thesis for plagiarism, and in 2020, it adopted a comprehensive policy specifically prohibiting plagiarism. These actions signal that AAU takes academic integrity seriously and will enforce its standards regardless of the individuals involved.

Consequences of Violations

The university views violations of academic integrity as serious offenses that undermine the value of AAU degrees and the reputation of the institution. As stated in the university's policy framework: “Violation of academic standards isn't a minor misdemeanor. The academic world depends upon the bona fides of examiners and peer reviewers. If a hitherto-reputable university awards degrees for reasons other than academic excellence, its reputation and the value of its degrees is debased”.

3. Plagiarism Rules and Regulations

Official Definition of Plagiarism

Addis Ababa University defines plagiarism as “the unauthorized use or close imitation of the language and thoughts of another author and the representation of them as one's own original work”. This includes both intentional copying and unintentional failure to properly attribute sources.

What Constitutes Plagiarism

The university recognizes several forms of plagiarism:

Type of Plagiarism	Description	Example
Direct Plagiarism	Word-for-word copying without quotation marks or citation	Copying a paragraph from a book into an essay
Mosaic Plagiarism	Patching together phrases from sources without proper attribution	Changing a few words in a sentence while maintaining the original structure
Self-Plagiarism	Reusing one's own previously submitted work without permission	Submitting the same paper for two different courses
Source-based Plagiarism	Citing sources inaccurately or citing nonexistent sources	Listing references not actually consulted
Paraphrasing Plagiarism	Rewording someone else's ideas without citation	Restating a published argument as one's own original thought

Detection Methods

AAU employs several methods to detect plagiarism:

- **Turnitin and Similar Software:** The university uses plagiarism detection software to screen theses, dissertations, and other student work
- **Manual Review:** Faculty members are trained to identify suspicious passages and writing inconsistencies
- **Cross-Checking:** Theses and dissertations are checked against unpublished reports, student theses, technical manuals, and other gray literature

Acceptable Similarity Thresholds

While specific thresholds may vary by department and level of study, a Turnitin similarity score of 62% or higher is considered “very high” and would typically result in outright rejection of a thesis. In standard practice, a responsible supervisor should not allow a thesis with excessive similarity to proceed to examination.

Consequences of Plagiarism

The university's policy on plagiarism includes graduated sanctions depending on the severity and intent of the violation:

- **For Undergraduate Students:** Course failure, academic probation, or suspension
- **For Graduate Students:** Thesis rejection, degree revocation, or expulsion
- **For Degree Holders:** Revocation of degrees already awarded, as demonstrated by AAU's 2019 rescission of a Master's thesis

Degree Revocation Authority

AAU explicitly reserves the right to revoke degrees in cases of significant falsification of data or plagiarism. The university recognizes that “academic institutions have the obligation to revoke a degree in cases of significant falsification of data or plagiarism”. This authority extends to degrees already conferred, meaning that discovery of plagiarism years after graduation can result in degree revocation.

4. Attendance Policy

General Attendance Requirements

Regular class attendance is mandatory for all registered students at Addis Ababa University. The university considers attendance integral to the learning process and a prerequisite for successful course completion.

Registration and Class Assignment

Students must complete online registration to be assigned to a section. The university explicitly warns that “failure to do so may result in difficulties in attending classes and course assessment entry by the instructors”. This means that students who are not properly registered cannot attend classes and will not receive grades.

Class Schedule Information

After registration, students must:

- Check their assigned section on the student portal
- Check their college noticeboard for class schedules
- Report to the correct campus and classroom as assigned

Campus Assignment Compliance

Students assigned to a new campus must complete clearance forms and access new facilities through the college's student service office. Attending classes at the wrong campus without proper clearance may result in attendance not being recorded.

Absence Due to Extracurricular Activities

The university's Extracurricular Activities and Sports Policy recognizes that participation in approved activities may require absence from class. However,

“participation in the Extracurricular Activities and Sports program is a privilege that carries additional expectations for acceptable conduct”. Students participating in such activities remain responsible for completing all course requirements.

NG Grade and Attendance Issues

Students who receive “NG” (No Grade) designations due to attendance problems must:

- Appeal to the College Academic Affairs Office
- Have the case processed according to AAU SL (2024) Articles 95.4 – 95.7 and 104
- After resolving the grade issue, request program placement from the Main Registrar's Office

5. Disciplinary Actions and Procedures

Legal Framework for Discipline

Student discipline at AAU is governed primarily by the Senate Legislation and supplementary discipline policies. As noted in the Recreation and Sport Policy, all student activities are subject to “the University's Legislation (articles 175 to 185)”, which establishes the framework for student conduct and disciplinary procedures.

Types of Disciplinary Violations

Disciplinary matters at AAU fall into several categories:

Violation Category	Examples	Potential Sanctions
Academic	Plagiarism, cheating,	Grade penalties, course failure,

Misconduct	falsification of data	suspension, expulsion, degree revocation
Behavioral Misconduct	Disruptive behavior, harassment, violence	Warning, probation, suspension, expulsion
Facility Misuse	Unauthorized use of university facilities	Revocation of privileges, fines
Policy Violations	Violation of published university policies	As specified in each policy

Examination Hall Violations

The UAT Information Booklet provides detailed guidance on prohibited items and behaviors in examination settings. These rules apply to all university-administered tests :

Prohibited Items in Testing Rooms:

- Electronic devices (cell phones, smartphones, tablets, smart watches, laptops)
- Internet access devices (Wi-Fi routers, portable hotspots)
- Communication devices (headphones, earphones, Bluetooth devices)
- Books, notes, study materials, textbooks, handouts, pamphlets, scratch papers
- Unauthorized calculators (scientific and programmable calculators prohibited)
- Unauthorized aids (rulers, protractors, compasses, formula sheets)

Consequences: Students found with prohibited items may be removed from the examination hall, have their tests invalidated, and face additional disciplinary action.

Cheating and Academic Fraud

The university maintains a zero-tolerance policy toward cheating and academic fraud. “Maintain the highest level of integrity during the test by not engaging in any form of cheating, or getting unauthorized assistance” is explicitly listed as a responsibility of all test takers.

Disciplinary Process

While specific procedural details are contained in the Senate Legislation, the general disciplinary process includes:

- **Reporting:** Violations are reported to the Dean of Students or College Academic Affairs Office
- **Investigation:** Facts are gathered and the student is given an opportunity to respond
- **Hearing:** For serious matters, a disciplinary committee hearing may be convened
- **Decision:** Sanctions are determined based on the nature and severity of the violation
- **Appeal:** Students may appeal decisions through established channels

Role of the Dean of Students

The Dean of Students holds significant responsibility for discipline, particularly in matters related to extracurricular activities and student conduct outside the classroom. According to policy, “The Dean of Students is the responsible body for approving the purposes and goals of an extracurricular activity and sports and ensuring that they are appropriate to the age, physical, and intellectual maturity of the students”.

6. Grading Appeals Process

Grade Disputes and NG Cases

When students believe a grade has been assigned incorrectly or unfairly, they have the right to appeal. The university has established procedures specifically for addressing “NG” (No Grade) designations and other grade-related issues.

NG Grade Appeal Procedure

For students who receive “NG” grades, the following procedure applies:

- **Initial Appeal:** Students must appeal to the College Academic Affairs Office
- **Case Processing:** The office processes the case according to AAU SL (2024) Articles 95.4 – 95.7 and 104
- **Resolution:** After the grade issue is resolved, the Vice Dean must request program placement from the Main Registrar's Office

Grounds for Grade Appeals

Valid grounds for grade appeals typically include:

- Computational errors in grade calculation
- Failure to consider submitted work
- Application of standards inconsistent with the course syllabus
- Discrimination or bias in grading

Appeal Timeline

Students must adhere to published deadlines for grade appeals. The university's announcement system and college notice boards provide specific timelines each semester.

Late appeals are generally not considered unless exceptional circumstances can be demonstrated.

Documentation Requirements

Students filing grade appeals should prepare:

- Written statement explaining the grounds for appeal
- Supporting evidence (graded assignments, emails, course syllabus)
- Any relevant correspondence with the instructor

Grade Changes After Graduation

The university's authority to change grades extends beyond graduation in cases of discovered academic misconduct. As noted in the plagiarism policy, degrees may be revoked if significant falsification or plagiarism is discovered after graduation.

7. Examination Regulations

Types of Examinations

AAU administers several types of examinations:

Exam Type	Purpose	Administering Body
Course Examinations	Assess performance in specific courses	Individual colleges/departments
Graduate Admission Test (GAT)	Screen applicants for graduate programs	AAU Testing Center
Undergraduate Admission Test (UAT)	Assess candidates for undergraduate	AAU Testing Center

	admission	
Comprehensive/Qualifying Exams	Assess graduate student readiness for candidacy	Respective colleges

Graduate Admission Test (GAT) Regulations

The GAT is required for all applicants to graduate programs at AAU, with specific exemptions for those with valid international test results (GRE, GMAT, IELTS, TOEFL, ACT, SAT, LSAT).

Key GAT Requirements:

- Application must be completed online through the AAU portal
- Testing fee: 750 ETB (or USD 50 equivalent for foreign applicants)
- Digital format administered electronically
- Photo upload required during registration
- Admission ticket must be printed and presented at exam hall

Undergraduate Admission Test (UAT) Regulations

The UAT assesses candidates for undergraduate studies, testing verbal and quantitative reasoning abilities.

UAT Structure:

- Verbal Reasoning Section: 55 items, 60 minutes
- Quantitative Reasoning Section: 45 items, 90 minutes
- Total: 100 multiple-choice questions, 2.5 hours

Examination Day Procedures

Arrival Requirements:

- Morning session: Arrive by 8:00 a.m. or earlier
- Afternoon session: Arrive by 1:00 p.m. or earlier

Required Materials:

- Valid identification document
- Printed admission ticket
- Acceptable calculator (four-function only)
- Pen or pencil for rough work

What Students Receive:

- Blank sheet of paper for rough work (collected at end of test)

Digital Examination Format

Both GAT and UAT are administered digitally through AAU's testing portal using the university's private network infrastructure. Benefits of the digital format include:

- Improved efficiency
- Streamlined test administration
- Automated scoring processes

Section Time Limits

Students must strictly adhere to time limits for each section. “Each section will automatically close once the allotted time has passed, prompting test takers to proceed to the next section. It is strictly prohibited to attempt to move between sections before the allocated time has elapsed”.

Missed Examinations

Students who fail to appear for scheduled examinations face the following consequences:

- Must re-register for the test
- Must repay all applicable fees
- Must wait for the next scheduled test administration

Accommodations for Students with Disabilities

The university provides reasonable accommodations for test takers with disabilities:

- **Disclosure Requirement:** Students must disclose their specific disability type during the application process
- **Visually Impaired Students:** Utilize the screen reader JAWS to complete tests; individual readers are not permitted
- **Other Disabilities:** Students are assigned to rooms suitable for their specific needs
- **Communication:** Students should actively communicate requirements to the testing center coordinator

Test Score Validity

GAT score validity varies by academic year. According to recent announcements:

- For 2025/26 admissions: GAT results from the previous year (as of September 2024) remain valid
- For other periods: Previous year's GAT results may not be accepted

Students must verify current policies at the time of application.

8. Campus Regulations

Use of University Facilities

Access to and use of university facilities is governed by the Senate Legislation, particularly articles 183 and related provisions.

General Principles:

- All recognized student clubs and organizations receive equal access to facilities
- Facilities are available during non-instructional time
- Use must be approved through proper channels

Extracurricular Activities and Clubs

The university encourages student participation in extracurricular activities while maintaining appropriate oversight.

Club Formation Requirements:

- Minimum of five students as members
- Recognition process follows articles 175 to 185 of the Senate Legislation
- Approval from Dean of Students required

Student Rights:

- Form clubs based on interest
- Organize educational or recreational events
- Conduct panel discussions, workshops, exhibitions, debates
- Access university facilities during non-instructional time

Non-Discrimination Policy

The university explicitly prohibits discrimination in all its forms:

> "Extracurricular activities and sports shall oppose any discrimination on the grounds of gender, ethnic, religious or political outlook etc."

This commitment extends to:

- Equal access for male and female students
- Opportunities for students with disabilities

- Respect for diversity in cultural values and social environment

Recreation and Sports Facilities

The university maintains recreational and sports arenas in all campuses and commits to providing fair and equitable access.

Sports Competitions:

- Intramural competitions organized annually in each campus
- Intercampus competitions for regular undergraduate students
- Participation in Government's Higher Education Sports Festival
- Inclusion of both sexes and disabled students

Student Housing Regulations

Students assigned to campus housing must:

- Complete clearance forms through the college's student service office
- Comply with dormitory rules and regulations
- Access cafeteria facilities according to established procedures

Campus Safety and Security

Students are expected to cooperate with university security measures and comply with all safety regulations. Specific requirements may vary by campus and facility.

ICT Facility Usage

AAU maintains extensive computer centers with internet-connected computers for student use. Usage is governed by the university's ICT policies, which prohibit:

- Unauthorized access to systems
- Use of university networks for illegal activities

- Damage to or theft of equipment

Registration Locations by Program

Students must register at specific locations based on their program of study:

Program	Registration Location
Doctor of Medicine, Dental Medicine, Pharmacy, Other Health Sciences	College of Health Sciences @ Tikur Anbessa Campus
Pre-engineering (EIABC)	College of Technology and Built Environment @ Lideta Campus
Pre-engineering (AAIT)	College of Technology and Built Environment @ 5 Kilo Campus
Computer Science, Information Systems, Other Natural Sciences	College of Natural and Computational Sciences @ 4 Kilo Campus
Doctor of Veterinary Medicine, Veterinary Laboratory Technology	College of Veterinary Medicine and Agriculture @ Bishoftu Campus
Law	School of Law @ Main Campus
Other Social Sciences	College of Social Sciences, Arts and Humanities, College of Education and Language Studies, College of Business and Economics @ 6 Kilo, Commerce Campus, and Performing and Visual Arts Campus

Campus Transfer Procedures

Students changing campuses must:

- Contact the college's student service office
- Complete required clearance forms
- Access new dormitory and cafeteria facilities through proper channels

9. Policy Enforcement and Student Responsibilities

Student Obligations

Every student at Addis Ababa University bears the responsibility to:

- **Familiarize Themselves with Policies:** Take time to review and understand all applicable university policies
- **Adhere to Instructions:** Follow all instructions provided by university administrators, faculty, and staff
- **Maintain Integrity:** Uphold the highest level of academic and personal integrity
- **Use Authorized Materials Only:** Only use materials, resources, or aids explicitly permitted
- **Present Valid Identification:** Produce valid ID and required documents when requested
- **Arrive on Time:** Meet all deadlines and scheduled appointments

Authority for Policy Implementation

Different university offices bear responsibility for implementing specific policies:

Policy Area	Responsible Office/Officer
Academic Affairs	Academic Vice President, College Academic Affairs Offices
Student Discipline	Dean of Students, College Academic Affairs Offices
Extracurricular Activities	Dean of Students, Associate Dean for Extracurricular Activities and Sports
Examinations	AAU Testing Center, ICT Directorate, Registrar Office
Registration	Office of the Registrar, College Registrars
Facility Use	Dean of Students, respective facility managers

Related Policies

The university's policy framework includes interconnected documents that students should consult for complete information:

- Senate Legislation (primary governing document)
- Health Policy
- Discipline Policy
- Individual college and department policies

Policy Updates and Announcements

Students are responsible for staying informed about policy updates through:

- The AAU portal (portal.aau.edu.et)
- College notice boards
- Official Telegram channels (e.g., Testing Center-AAU @aauGAT)
- University website announcements

Questions and Clarifications

Students with questions about university policies should:

- Contact their College Registrar's Office
- Consult with the Dean of Students
- Refer to official university publications and websites
- Seek guidance from academic advisors

10. Useful References and Contact Information

Key University Offices

Office	Responsibility	Location/Contact
Office of the Registrar	Registration, academic records, admissions	Main Campus, Registrar Building
Dean of Students	Student affairs, discipline, extracurricular activities	Various campuses
AAU Testing Center	GAT, UAT, and other examinations	Institute of Educational Research (IER)
College Academic Affairs Offices	Grade appeals, academic issues	Respective colleges
ICT Directorate	Technology support, portal access	+251-111-223862

Official Online Portals

- **AAU Main Website:**http://www.aau.edu.et/
- **Student Portal:**https://portal.aau.edu.et/
- **Admission Portal:**https://admission.aau.edu.et/
- **Graduate Programs:**https://admission.aau.edu.et/GraduatePrograms

Official Communication Channels

- **Telegram (Testing Center-AAU):** t.me/aauGAT
- **College Notice Boards:** Physical locations at each college
- **University Announcements:**http://www.aau.edu.et/blog/category/announcements/

Key Policy References

- AAU Senate Legislation (2024) – Primary governing document
- AAU Discipline Policy – Detailed disciplinary procedures
- AAU Academic Integrity Policy – Plagiarism and academic misconduct
- Extracurricular Activities and Sports Policy – Student activities and club regulations

Important Reminders

- **Deadlines:** All university deadlines are strictly enforced. "Please stick to the deadlines and follow the instructions carefully".
- **Documentation:** Maintain copies of all documents submitted to the university, including registration confirmations, admission tickets, and official correspondence.

- **Communication:** Regularly check official communication channels for updates that may affect your academic standing.
- **Compliance:** Ignorance of policies is not an excuse for violations. Take time to understand your rights and responsibilities as an AAU student.